

Cultivating Communities of Practice: Chapter 2 Excerpt (Wenger et al., 2002)

Reading Notes

CoPs are voluntary → attracting & engaging members requires them to be able to generate excitement, relevance, and/or value (basically, “aliveness”)

that means you want to design for aliveness

community design aims to surface the community’s internal direction, character, and energy

their seven design principles:

1. design for evolution
 - a. don’t try to over-structure or speed things along too much
 - b. consider how to bring people together (around spaces, meetings, etc.)
2. open a dialogue between inside and outside perspectives
 - a. insiders have key knowledge & experience and can help discern the purpose of the community
 - b. outsiders are often better at seeing the potential of the community
3. invite different levels of participation
 - a. core group (regular, active participants and leaders), usually 10-15%
 - b. active group (regular attendees and participants, but not as much as the core group), usually 15-20%
 - c. peripheral members (those who rarely participate due to lack of time or lack of perceived expertise) - still very valuable and likely learning and doing more than you’d think at first glance
 - d. it’s okay and healthy for people to move between different levels of participation
4. develop both public and private community spaces
 - a. public here means that it’s open to all community members, not necessarily to the public
 - b. “the heart of a community is the web of relationships among community members”
 - c. having opportunities for private, smaller interactions is important (networking, connecting people to resources, etc.)
 - d. both types of interaction support each other:

- i. strong private relationships make for richer public events
 - ii. meaningful public events can help build private connections
- 5. focus on value
 - a. initial value in a CoP usually comes from solving immediate member problems, but that later shifts to include developing a systematic body of knowledge
 - b. value is not always immediately clear, and the true value of a CoP can take time to emerge
 - c. encourage community members to be explicit about the value of the CoP as it evolves
- 6. combine familiarity and excitement
 - a. help people know what to expect, but also allow opportunities for spontaneity and new things
- 7. create a rhythm for the community
 - a. find the sweet spot: too much and people feel overwhelmed, too little and people can lose interest
 - b. example: asynchronous communication may spike before and after regular meetings
 - c. different CoPs will have different rhythms

Reading Questions

1. What are the three structural elements of a community of practice? Using these three elements, describe whether the AI Campus Champions workshop cohort currently meets the definition of a CoP — or falls short on one or more elements.

The three key structure elements of a CoP are domain, community, and practice, although those are not mentioned in this reading. We currently have all three: AI functions as the domain (topic) around which we gather, community exists through our synchronous meetings and discussion board posts, and we share a common practice in considering how and where AI might be able to help improve the work that we do. However, whether the community aspect will last beyond the six weeks of the workshop remains to be seen.

2. Wenger et al. distinguish between 'core members' (active contributors), 'active members' (regular participants), and 'peripheral members' (observers). How should

an AI Campus Champion initiative accommodate all three participation levels without requiring everyone to become a core member?

Assuming that this initiative is intended to become a CoP, you would need a critical mass of people to commit to regular interaction (most likely meetings) to continue the conversation and work that we've been doing. There's no way to compel participation, so less active and/or peripheral participation would have to be possible by default. I think the key element would be the core group not seeing people who are participating less as lazy or freeriding.

3. The book argues that CoPs cannot be mandated — they must be cultivated. What are the implications for how an AI Campus Champion at a university should propose an AI literacy initiative to leadership? What language would create space for cultivation rather than imposing a mandate?

From this perspective, you'd want participation in the AI literacy initiative to be voluntary and allow people to attend when they can (or want) and participate at whatever level they're comfortable with. AI is a convenient topic for this because lots of people are interested and/or have things to say, so if you were to align the literacy initiative with aspects of AI that you know people care about, I suspect you'd get good turnout.

4. Wenger et al. identify 'knowledge stewarding' as a key CoP function — the active curation and sharing of the community's knowledge. What knowledge management structures (shared resources, meeting rhythms, documentation practices) would an AI Campus Champion network need to function as a genuine CoP?

There would likely need to be regular meetings, a way to store and share materials, and perhaps a place for asynchronous communication outside of meetings. Something like a Microsoft Teams space would work well initially for this since it offers all the necessary elements in one place.

Key Terms

Term	My Definition
Community of practice	a group of people who share a common practice and regularly interact regarding that practice

Domain (CoP)	not defined in the reading, but it refers to the topic/area around which a CoP is organized
Community (CoP)	not defined in the reading, but it refers to the group of people who organize and interact regarding a particular domain and practice
Practice (CoP)	not defined in the reading, but it refers to the particular tasks (physical, intellectual) that are involved in the work that a CoP does
Knowledge stewardship	managing the collective knowledge and products of a CoP in a way that makes them accessible to members
Legitimate peripheral participation	not defined in the reading, but it refers to a CoP allowing people to only occasionally or minimally be involved with the group

A Revision of Bloom's Taxonomy: An Overview (Krathwohl, 2002)

Reading Notes

one of the most common uses of Bloom's has been to point out that a lot of education has largely centered around recognizing, recalling, and at best understanding information

the revised taxonomy requires classifying an objective or learning activity according to both the kind of knowledge/skills involved and what learners are being asked to do with said knowledge/skills

Reading Questions

1. Map the six workshop modules to the six levels of Bloom's Revised Taxonomy. For each module, identify the primary cognitive process level targeted and one learning objective verb from that module that matches the taxonomy's recommended verbs.

Module	Primary Bloom's Level	Matching Verbs from Module Objectives
1	understand	summarize, explain
2	understand	compare, classify, explain
3	apply	complete (=carry out a procedure), apply
4	analyze	analyze, audit
5	evaluate	evaluate, assess
6	create	design, produce, formulate

2. The original Bloom's taxonomy (Bloom, 1956) used nouns (Knowledge, Comprehension, Application...); Anderson & Krathwohl revised it to use verbs (Remember, Understand, Apply...). Why does the verb formulation produce more measurable learning objectives?

It doesn't produce more measurable learning objectives, but it does make the process feel more active.

3. Anderson & Krathwohl add a fourth knowledge type — Metacognitive Knowledge — to the three in Bloom's original (Factual, Conceptual, Procedural). What is metacognitive knowledge? Give one example of a learning outcome in your professional domain that targets metacognitive knowledge.

Metacognitive knowledge is understanding thinking (metacognition = thinking about thinking), both one's own and others'. One learning outcome in my professional domain would be explaining common trajectories that instructors follow as they work to apply active learning practices in their teaching.

4. When designing an AI literacy learning experience for your colleagues, at which Bloom's level would you start — and why? What evidence from this workshop's design would you cite to justify your choice?

If you're designing for people whom you cannot assume to have much background knowledge, you need to start at the remember and understand levels. In this workshop, we did something similar by starting out with basic definitions.

Key Terms

Term	My Definition
Cognitive process dimension	classification of a task according to the type of mental effort that it requires
Knowledge dimension	a particular facet of knowledge, useful in categorizing different types of knowledge (in this case, factual, conceptual, procedural, metacognitive)
Learning objective verb	the action specified in a learning objective which helps to clarify the cognitive process involved
Metacognitive knowledge	knowing about thinking, including one's own and others'

Bloom's Revised Taxonomy	a system for classifying learning objectives and activities according to the mental effort and processes involved to achieve those objectives or carry out those activities
Measurable learning objective	not defined in the reading, but it's an objective written in such a way that one can clearly determine whether the objective has been achieved